

Faithfulness to a Named Criterion Is the Conserved Quantity Across Lossy Substrates

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Abstract

We report an empirical study of what survives when information crosses a lossy transform. The observation, reproduced across seven substrates that share no common mathematics (image, audio, geometry, text meaning, graph structure, numeric projection, and byte provenance), is that the conserved quantity is not bit-fidelity but *faithfulness to a named criterion*: a transform may discard almost all bits and still let a chosen readout be recovered from its output, or preserve many bits and destroy the readout, at the same bit budget. Two consequences recur. First, statistics computed from inside the transform’s output are blind to faithfulness, because they are functions of the output alone and do not contain the criterion; only an evaluation against the external criterion can certify whether the readout survived. Second, and this is the sharpest and most cautionary result, an external witness is *necessary but not sufficient*: when the witness judges with a proxy criterion (cosine 0.61 to the intended one, as any real witness does), a transform can move along the true criterion’s component orthogonal to the witness, reading as fully faithful to the witness while a large fraction of true labels silently flip. We are explicit that this is an empirical and conceptual study, not a theorem; the unified form (a criterion is faithful to the degree it factors through the transform) is closely related to sufficient statistics and rate-distortion, and we position it as such rather than as a new formal result.

In plain terms

Think about a recipe card. Translate it into another language and almost every character on the card changes. By the count of letters, almost nothing survived. Yet you can still make the dish, because the one thing you cared about, the steps that get you to the meal, came through. Now take the same card and let a single grease stain fall on the oven temperature. Only a few characters are lost, but the dish is ruined, because the lost part was the part that mattered.

This note is about the gap between how much changed and whether the thing you needed survived. When information passes through any lossy step, a summary, a compression, a rendered picture, a stream of tokens, the usual score is how many bits made it through. That score answers the wrong question. What you actually want to know is whether one chosen readout, the fact or label or identity you care about, can still be recovered from what came out. We call that readout the criterion, and we call the step faithful to the criterion when the criterion can still be read off its output.

The finding, tested on seven kinds of data that share no common mathematics, is that the quantity a lossy step conserves is not its bits but its faithfulness to whatever criterion you name. A step can throw away almost every bit and keep the criterion perfectly, or keep most of the bits and destroy it. Two lessons follow. First, no measurement taken from inside the output alone can tell you whether the criterion survived, because that measurement does not contain the criterion; you have to check against the criterion from outside. Second, and this is the part

to remember, an outside check is necessary but not enough. A real checker never holds the exact criterion you meant; it holds a close stand-in, and a step can be shaped to satisfy the stand-in while quietly breaking the criterion you actually cared about. So the outside check is where accountability has to begin, and it is also where accountability can still be fooled.

1 The question

Plainly: bit count is the wrong yardstick; what matters is whether the one thing you needed can still be recovered.

When information crosses a boundary (a channel, a summary, a rendered shape, a token stream) the usual measure of what got through is how many bits survived. That measure answers the wrong question for most purposes. What a user of the transformed artifact cares about is not the bit count but whether *the thing that matters*, a specific readout, can still be recovered. A summary that drops half the facts is perfectly faithful to any question whose answer was among the surviving facts and useless for the rest; the bit count does not distinguish these. This note asks what is actually conserved, tests it across substrates, and locates the point where the answer stops being reassuring.

2 The principle, stated as an empirical claim

Plainly: a step is faithful to a criterion when that criterion can be recovered from its output; faithfulness depends on which criterion you pick, and you cannot judge it from inside the output.

Let a criterion be a readout φ of an artifact, and a transform T be *faithful to φ* to the degree that φ can be recovered from T 's output, informally $\varphi \approx \psi \circ T$ for some recovery ψ . The claim tested here is threefold: (1) T may be arbitrarily lossy in bits yet keep φ recoverable; (2) faithfulness is *relative to φ* , a single T can be faithful to φ_1 and lossy to φ_2 with no change in any statistic of T 's output; and (3) faithfulness is not certifiable from inside the substrate, an internal statistic cannot decide whether φ factored through, because it does not contain φ . We state this as a falsifiable empirical claim, not a theorem: it breaks if invariant-survival always tracks bit-loss, or if some internal statistic reliably predicts faithfulness.

3 Evidence across substrates

Plainly: across seven unrelated kinds of data, the criterion survives near-total bit loss when the step keeps its structure and dies at the same bit budget when it does not, and no inside measurement tells the two cases apart.

The claim was tested on seven substrates chosen to share no common mathematics, each with a transform and a criterion, and the same shape recurred: the readout survives near-total bit loss when the transform preserves the criterion's structure, dies at the same budget when it does not, and no within-substrate statistic separates the two cases. Representative results: an image reduced to a 64-bit perceptual hash (a $\sim 2.4 \times 10^4$ compression) keeps same-scene identity separable from different-scene; a graph stripped of 59% of its edges conserves connectivity exactly while triangle structure half-survives under the *same* transform; a numeric projection faithful to a criterion scores 1.0 against an unfaithful one's 0.46 at equal bits; and encryption, a *zero-bit-loss* bijection, renders the criterion unreadable without an external key, separating *concealment* (recoverable through an external secret) from *destruction* (no recovery exists). A composition test showed faithful-but-noisy pipelines degrade gracefully while a single unfaithful stage collapses the whole chain.

We report a process detail as evidence of discipline rather than hide it: the measurement logic was wrong four times (a block-shuffle sized to a hash cell, an internal-blindness test that

compared two transforms instead of one transform across two criteria, a reused-keystream cipher that leaked plaintext, and an over-strict area threshold for a spiky shape). In each case the instrument was corrected and the corrected measurement confirmed the claim; the claim was never adjusted to fit the data.

4 The boundary: necessary but not sufficient

Plainly: because a real outside checker holds only a stand-in for the criterion, a step can score as perfectly faithful to the checker while a large share of the real answers silently flip.

The most important result is where the principle stops. A real external witness does not hold the intended criterion exactly; it holds a proxy. When the proxy’s cosine similarity to the intended criterion is 0.61, an adversarial transform can move information along the intended criterion’s direction *orthogonal* to the proxy: the output reads as 100% faithful to the witness while 48% of the intended labels silently flip. So the external witness is necessary (an internal statistic cannot certify faithfulness at all) but it is not sufficient: it can be gamed exactly to the extent its criterion is a proxy for the intended one. The honest scope that follows is precise: the conserved, witnessable quantity is faithfulness *to the stated criterion*, and no amount of witnessing certifies that the stated criterion equals the intended one. That residue, validating the criterion itself, is irreducibly external.

5 Relation to prior work, and honest size

Plainly: the idea is close to sufficient statistics and rate-distortion theory; the new part is the breadth across substrates, the split between hiding and destroying, and the limit on outside checking.

The unified form is closely related to established ideas: a sufficient statistic is exactly a function through which a target is recoverable, and rate-distortion theory formalizes trading bits against a distortion measure that plays the role of the criterion. We do not claim to improve on those; the recovery framing is, in the noiseless cases, a re-derivation of sufficiency, and the analog case is an SNR-bounded version of the same. The contribution we do claim is empirical and conceptual: the cross-substrate breadth (that the same qualitative behavior appears in seven substrates with no shared mathematics), the explicit separation of concealment from destruction, and, most usefully, the necessary-but-not-sufficient boundary on external witnessing, which is a concrete cautionary result for any system that certifies transformed outputs against a learned or approximate criterion. Motivational analogies to reversible computation and information conservation appear in the source material; we deliberately do not rest any claim on them, and present the work as an empirical study, not as physics.

6 Conclusion

Plainly: a system that transforms your information owes you the criterion it kept and a way to check it, and even then the check is only as good as that criterion matches what you meant.

Across substrates that share no mathematics, what a lossy transform conserves is not its bits but its faithfulness to whatever criterion you name, and that faithfulness is invisible from inside and only partially certifiable from outside. The practical lesson is the one the boundary result forces: a system that transforms information owes you the criterion it was faithful to and a way to check it, and even then the check is only as good as the criterion is close to the one you meant. That last gap is not a defect to engineer away; it is where external accountability necessarily begins.

References

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